Babel's In Arms

By David Ives

Enter two workers, ***GORPH*** *and* ***CANNAPHLIT*** *Primitive tools hang from their belts. They are carrying between them an enormous rectangular building stone, maybe five feet long and two feet high. They inch slowly toward center with it, as . . .*

GORPH: *(groaning under the stone's weight)* Okay. . .Okay. . . Okay. . .Stop. *(A moment, as they catch their breath.)*

CANNAPHLIT: Okay?

GORPH: Go.

BOTH: *(ad lib, moving toward center)* Okay. Okay. Okay. Okay.

GORPH: Stop. *(They catch their breath a moment.)* Go. *(They move a few inches.)* Stop. *(They stop to catch their breath)* Go.

CANNAPHLIT: *(at center now)* Stop.

GORPH: Okay. Down. *(They slowly lower the stone.)* Down. Down. Down. Down. Down. Stop. *(looks at it.)* Behold! . . . . It's backwards. *(They go in a circle.)* Circle

CANNAPHLIT: Circle.

GORPH: Stop. Okay. Down. . . Down. . . Down. . . Stop. *(They now have it an inch over the ground.)* One. Two. Five. Go! *(They drop the stone to the ground.)* Behold the stone!

INTRODUCTION

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CANNAPHLIT: Behold the stone! Big stone. *(They moan, they groan, they stretch, they wipe sweat from each other's foreheads.)* But what is a "stone," O, Gorph, son of Khlekhmalekhm?

GORPH: That heavy thing there. That is a stone, O, Cannaphlit, son of Bob.

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CANNAPHLIT: Ah, so that is a stone. But is this stone in the right place, O, Groph, son of Khlekhmalekhm?

GORPH: I will consult the plans, O, Cannaphlit, son of Bob. *(He takes out a large parchment roll.)* Behold the plans.

CANNAPHLIT: Behold the plans! *(GORPH unrolls a blueprint-a large blue sheet of paper with just a single white rectangle in the middle.)*

GORPH: *(After inspecting the plans)* The stone must move one sixteenth of an ell to the north!

CANNAPHLIT: One sixteenth of an ell! How far is that?

GORPH: About an inch.

CANNAPHLIT: *(as GORPH takes out the crowbar)* O my friend? What is that?

GORPH: This item has no name, for humanity is young and has not words yet for every item. Basically, it's a rigid rod that pivots about a fulcrum and is used to move an object at point A by applying force at point B. . . . I call it a lever.

CANNAPHLIT: Behold the lever!

GORPH: *(With a huge grunt, he levers the stone an inch to the lift; that done, he checks, and nudges it with his toe one last small bit.)* The stone is now in place.

CANNAPHLIT: The stone is in place! *(They snort, high-five, shake hands, flex muscles, grab crotch, and generally male-display.)* So what is the stone for, O, Gorph?

GORPH: This stone? This stone is for. . . You mean thou dost not know?

CANNAPHLIT: I dost not know. *(They regard, the stone a moment.)*

A BUSINESSWOMAN in a killer suit with a large sword in a scabbard, enters sets up a sign that says "FUTURE HOME OF BABEL."

GORPH: *(reading the sign)* "Future Home of Baybel."

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BSWOMAN: Babble. It's not "Baybel." It's Babble. Now listen up, you rotten stinking men.I represent a consortium of off-desert investors who want to develop this property. Our mandate is to build a tower whose top will reach to the very heavens, indeed, into heaven, indeed, as high as God. This in order to show that we are equal to same aforesaid God.

GORPH: That we are equal to God?

BSWOMAN: No, that ***we***, not ***you***, are equal to same aforesaid God. You are nothing. You are scum, but you build the tower. Have you got that?

GORPH: We're scum. We build the tower.

BSWOMAN: In the event that same aforesaid God is not pleased, the consortium is not responsible for any long-term apocalyptic events. Sign here. *(presents a parchment; Gorph and Cannaphlit sign and she immediately takes it away)* Understood. Now. The most important thing. And this is absolutely crucial. Are you listening? *(They nod.)* Do not - under any circumstances - khlumnafluffa himnaflekh.

CANNAPHLIT: Do not khlumnafluffa bimbaflekh?

BSWOMAN: ***Himmm***-naflekh.

CANNAPHLIT: ***Himmmmm***-naflekh.

BSWOMAN: *(pulls sword from its scabbard)* Instructions clear? Or else you die.

GORPH: Mm-hm... Oh yeah. . . I think so . . . Very clear. . .

BSWOMAN: One last crucial thing. Did you bring the shpoont?

GORPH: Oh, the shpoont.

CANNAPHLIT: I think we have the shpoont.

GORPH: The shpoont was here a moment ago.

BSWOMAN: Do not proceed without the shpoont. *(takes out the sword)* Or else you die. I'll be checking in very soon. Now get to work. *(Businesswoman exits.)*

GORPH: Khlumnafluffa himnaflekh . . .

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CANNAPHLIT: Khlumnafluffa himnaflekh. . . .

GORPH: What the heyyyyy is that?

CANNAPHLIT: That was a little vague. The other instructions were pretty clear.

GORPH: Oh yes? Repeat the instructions. Refresh my memory.

CANNAPHLIT: Build a tower whose top reaches to the very heavens, indeed, into heaven, indeed as high as God. Proving that ***they*** - not we because we are scum - that ***they*** are equal to same aforesaid God.

GORPH: That's very clear.

CANNAPHLIT: And don't khlumnafluffa himnaflekh, or you die.

GORPH: And don't forget the shpoont. *(They look at each other and shrug)*

CANNAPHLIT: Maybe we could put a portico on the tower, in pink, do a rich pink ceiling, maybe use that sponging technique. . .

GORPH: But consider this, O son of Bob. Putting the pink portico aside for a moment. Why? Let us nail down why. Name an attribute of God. Go ahead. Just pick an attribute, any attribute.

CANNAPHLIT: God is fairly powerful.

GORPH: Powerful. Mm-hmm . . .. Any other attributes?

CANNAPHLIT: I'd say God is eternal and infinite.

GORPH: Infinite. Let's pause there for a nanosecond. How high would a tower have to be to meet an infinite God?

CANNAPHLIT: Hmmm. *(He ponders that a moment, then raises his hand like a student.)*

GORPH: *(teacher)* Cannaphlit?

CANNAPHLIT: Infinitely high?

GORPH: Infinitely high. So you're going infinitely high – how broad would the base of same aforesaid tower would have to be? Just gimme a rough guesstimate. *(Pause as Cannaphlit ponders that. Then he raises his hand again like a student.*)

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GORPH: *(teacher)* Cannaphlit?

CANNAPHLIT: Infinitely broad?

GORPH: Innnnfinitely broad. How many stones would we have to use? An innnnnnfinite number of stones. And how long did it take us to get this stone here?

CANNAPHLIT: Two years.

GORPH: So our task is to build a tower infinitely high, infinitely broad, from an infinite number of stones, shake hands with God **AND** - do not khlumnafluffa himnaflekh while using the shpoont.

CANNAPHLIT: It's gonna be work.

GORPH: It's gonna be work.

CANNAPHLIT: *(brilliant idea)* Maybe we should get out of it!

GORPH: But how, O brilliant Son of Bob? We just say no? But we need a reason. So when they ask us why we've laid down our tools, we say. . . ?

CANNAPHLIT: We could tell them God doesn't exist.

GORPH: I love it! It's simple. It's elegant.

CANNAPHLIT: What could they do?

GORPH: Cut off our heads! *(They ponder the dilemma for a moment, grunting)*

CANNAPHLIT: Wait a minute. Who says God is in the sky?

GORPH: Yeah! Where did this arcane idea come from?

CANNAPHLIT: Maybe God isn't up, maybe God is down.

GORPH: Oh, man, it's brilliant. Brilliant!

CANNAPHLIT: We don't have to build a tower infinitely high and infinitely broad! We just have to dig a big hole! *(They celebrate, but then realize)*

BOTH: An infinite hole. . .

CANNAPHLIT: Wait a minute. *(tapping his head with a brilliant idea)* Candlepower! Candlepower!

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GORPH: What've you got? What. What. What.

CANNAPHLIT: We tell them God is everywhere. If God is everywhere, you don't have to build a tower or dig a hole or nothin' !

GORPH: Because we're already there. *(They celebrate wildly for a moment, then stop suddenly.)* Is it true?

CANNAPHLIT: I don't know. We could say it. *(They go back to celebrating.)*

BOTH: Whoo-EEEEE!

CANNAPHLIT: We're there, buddy! **GORPH:** We did it!

(They snort, high-five, shake hands, flex their muscles, grab their crotches, and generally male display. The Businesswoman comes in and watches them celebrate.)

BSWOMAN: So how are we doing?

GORPH: Good. Good. We're doing good. Excellent.

CANNAPHLIT: There it is.

GORPH: *(arms wide over the audience)* Behold!

CANNAPHLIT: *(arms wide over the audience – a pause)* The tower!

GORPH: Shake hands with God, baby. 'Cause we are **DONE**.

BSWOMAN: *(draws the sword)* Explain this to my trusty sword.

CANNAPHLIT: Well... You don't need a tower because God is everywhere. You see?

BSWOMAN: I see nothing. And my sword sees nothing.

CANNAPHLIT: Maybe you're not looking hard enough. *(points)* God is here. *(points elsewhere)* God is here . . .

GORPH: God's up there, God's down there. I swear to God. Who is everywhere. As you see. *(Silence.)*

BSWOMAN: Did you khlumnafluffa himnaflekh?

BOTH: Oh no. No, no. Uh-uh. Never. Not at all. Mmmm. Don't think of it. Nope. No way.

BSWOMAN: Did you use the shpoont?

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GORPH: Constantly.

BSWOMAN: I don't believe you. Prepare to die. *(She raises the sword.)*

CANNAPHLIT: We saved your life! The tower you wanted would've taken an ***innnnnfinite*** number of stones which would've cost an ***innnnfinite*** number of schmootzkels. Consortium calls you in! You're cold cuts, babe. *(The Businesswoman considers that a moment.)*

BSWOMAN: Gentlemen - I LOVE THIS TOWER. It's beautiful! It's got balance, it's got harmony.

GORPH: Put together an infinite number of nothing - eventually, you get this.

CANNAPHLIT: How do you like the portico?

BSWOMAN: The portico is my favorite part! Congratulations! *(Now all three of them snort, Flex, shake hands, etc.)* Well you guys did a terrific job and the Consortium thanks you. So as a bonus here's a bag of cow manure for you. *(Gives a dripping bag to Gorph and another to Cannaphlit)* And a bag of cow manure for you.

GORPH: Golly. Thanks a lot. That's cow manure all right.

CANNAPHLIT: Nice and fresh too.

BSWOMAN: As an option you could be castrated and be sacred eunuchs.

BOTH: *(ad lib)* Oh, that's all right. . . I think the cow manure is enough. . .

BSWOMAN: We won't forget this. Thank you.

CANNAPHLIT: Our pleasure.

BSWOMAN: Don't spread that all in one place. *(Businesswoman exits.)*

GORPH: Tower to God, huh. Easier than I thought.

CANNAPHLIT: *(lifting up his bag of manure)* This is where thinking'll get you!

GORPH: So listen. Now we found God - you wanna invent the wheel?

CANNAPHLIT: Yeah. What's a wheel?

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AWARD HISTORY

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